

New Generation English B· Diagnostic Test

B2 (Upper-Intermediate Exam Route) B· Full Test

READING

Why students are returning to paper books

For nearly two decades, paper textbooks were widely predicted to disappear from student life. Forecasts in education journals between 2005 and 2015 confidently suggested that by 2025 the average student would carry only a tablet. The reality has been very different. A growing body of research, particularly in Northern Europe and parts of Asia, shows that university students are now actively choosing paper books for serious reading even when digital versions are cheaper, lighter and immediately available.

The reasons are not nostalgic. In repeated studies, students who read complex academic texts on paper outperform their peers reading the same texts on screens, especially on tasks that require sustained inference rather than quick fact retrieval. The difference is small for short pieces, but consistent for anything longer than about a thousand words.

Researchers offer several explanations. Paper does not interrupt the reader; it does not buzz, glow, or invite a parallel browser window. It encourages physical landmarks a particular paragraph is remembered as being near the top of a specific page that screens cannot easily replicate. And it discourages the temptation, common among digital natives, to scroll quickly and assume understanding.

This does not amount to a rejection of digital tools. The same students typically use laptops for searches, note-taking and quick reference. What they are doing, instead, is matching the medium to the task: digital for fast and connected work, paper for slow and analytical reading. The interesting question is whether libraries, publishers and even universities themselves will respond by treating this choice as serious or continue to assume that the digital future is the only future worth planning for.

1. What did journals between 2005 and 2015 confidently predict?

- A) That paper textbooks would disappear by 2025.**
- B) That tablets would become more expensive.
- C) That universities would close their libraries.

2. What does a growing body of research show?

- A) Students prefer audio books.
- B) Students are actively choosing paper books for serious reading.**
- C) Digital books are universally superior.

3. On what kind of task do paper-readers especially outperform screen-readers?

- A) Quick fact retrieval.
- B) Tasks requiring sustained inference.**
- C) Short news articles.

4. When is the difference between paper and screen reading consistent?

A) Only on poetry.

B) For anything longer than about a thousand words.

C) Only on technical manuals.

5. What does paper NOT do, according to the text?

A) It does not buzz, glow, or invite a parallel browser window.

B) It does not show text.

C) It does not weigh anything.

6. What does paper encourage that screens cannot easily replicate?

A) Quick search results.

B) Physical landmarks for memory.

C) Automatic translation.

7. What do the same students typically use laptops for?

A) Only for entertainment.

B) Searches, note-taking and quick reference.

C) Long academic reading.

8. What is the interesting question raised at the end?

A) Whether libraries and universities will treat the choice as serious.

B) Whether tablets will become free.

C) Whether printing will be banned.

LISTENING

Radio segment: City Watch on the Paris case

Script:

Welcome back to City Watch. Today we are looking at Paris, which has been trying for nearly a decade to follow the Amsterdam model. The story is more nuanced than the headlines suggest.

Since 2014, Paris has built over 1,000 kilometres of cycle lanes, reduced car access in the city centre and expanded public squares. Critics often note that progress has been slower and messier than in Amsterdam. They are right, but they often miss the most important difference: Paris started from a much higher car density and a much wider street layout, both designed for traffic.

What surprised urban planners was not the resistance — every transformation produces resistance — but the speed at which behaviour shifted once infrastructure was provided. Within two years of opening protected lanes, cycling among women and older residents tripled. These are the groups that usually avoid cycling in unsafe conditions, so their participation is a strong indicator of real safety.

However, Paris has also revealed the limits of the Amsterdam model. Long suburban commutes still depend on cars. Many delivery vehicles cannot easily be replaced. The mayor's office has had to invest heavily in cargo bikes, electric vans and shared bike systems just to support what was previously taken for granted.

The lesson is not that Paris is failing or succeeding. It is that urban change is slow, expensive and political — and that no city can simply import another city's success.

1. How long has Paris been trying to follow the Amsterdam model?

A) Nearly a decade.

B) Almost fifty years.

C) Just three years.

2. How many kilometres of cycle lanes has Paris built since 2014?

A) Over 100.

B) Over 1,000.

C) Over 10,000.

3. What is the most important difference with Amsterdam?

A) The climate.

B) Higher car density and wider streets designed for traffic.

C) Tourism levels.

4. What surprised urban planners?

A) The resistance.

B) The speed at which behaviour shifted once infrastructure was provided.

C) The cost.

5. Which group tripled its cycling within two years?

A) Tourists.

B) Women and older residents.

C) Teenagers only.

6. Why is the participation of those groups a strong indicator?

A) They usually avoid cycling in unsafe conditions.

B) They have more money.

C) They live in the city centre.

7. What still depends mostly on cars?

A) School trips.

B) Long suburban commutes.

C) Tourist sightseeing.

8. What is the central lesson of the segment?

A) Paris has failed.

B) Every city should copy Amsterdam.

C) Urban change is slow, expensive and political.

WRITING

Write 180-220 words. Some experts argue that the most effective way to reduce urban traffic is to redesign cities around cyclists and pedestrians rather than improve cars and roads. To what extent do you agree? Support your view with examples and acknowledge one counter-argument.

SPEAKING

Record 2-3 minutes. Defend a position on rethinking urban transport. Include one concession, one historical or current example (Amsterdam, Paris or another city), and one condition under which your argument might not apply.

